

FCRS 405: Interfaith Encounter and Religious Dialogue

All Regular

Lecture Notes

Lecture Week 1: General Introduction

About the Course – Basic Requirements and Explanations

- Regular attendance at lectures is a basic requirement
- Full participation at lectures highly expected from students
- Only relevant questions will be tolerated
- No phone calls will be allowed. Phone may be used only in the context of using the biblical apps for reference purposes.
- Enrichment courses – not a catechesis, not a political tool to promote the Catholic faith. They are intended to give the Catholic education a true “catholic” (universal) character.

Understanding our Terms

Interfaith Dialogue (IFD):

- 1) **Faith** (from Latin *fides, fidei*) is confidence or trust in a person or thing natural or supernatural; or the observance of an obligation from loyalty; or fidelity to an entity, promise, or engagement.
- 2) The word “**faith**” may also refer to a particular system of **religious** beliefs, in which **faith** may equate confidence based on some perceived degree of warrant.
- 3) Faith can refer to what a person believes. In that case, we are talking about *faith as creed*, a set of belief tenets, written or unwritten.
- 4) Faith could also be how the person believes – the mode of your faith, the direction – Roman Catholic, Sunni, orthodox Jew etc.
- 5) Faith can also refer to who a person is – in other words, *faith is the totality of a person’s way of life*. Therefore, we can describe people’s faith with the verb “to be”. We often say, “he/she is a Jew, a Muslim, a Christian etc”. In this sense, faith is something one can identify a person with – it is like a fruit of a plant. The saying of Jesus in Scriptures holds true, “By their fruits you shall know them” (Mt 7:16). By your fruits people must be able to know the type of faith you have. In this sense faith can be said to be an identity marker.
- 6) In the words of Heb 11:1, “faith is the realization of what is hoped for and evidence of things not seen”. In this sense, faith is strongly connected with hope. For, faith is a firm belief in something beyond what can be empirically verified. The result is hope and love. Faith is thus a firm trust in God, in an individual or even in an inanimate thing.

Interfaith dialogue is a faith encounter involving persons with strong adherence to a deity (God, Allah, Yahweh, Buddha etc.), or an individual or other created things. The emphasis of IFD is on an encounter between person(s) of different faith. It involves faith as lived by the persons involved and encounter of such persons. Interfaith connotes a link between such faith tenets as lived by the individuals involved. We can therefore talk about interfaith marriage, interfaith service/worship, friendship, cooperation.

An interfaith dialogue takes place in our daily lives and at all the times, especially when people of differing religions encounter each other without necessarily discussing matters of faith such

as an encounter in a trotro, taxis, market place, work place – indeed, it is an encounter with other believers everywhere informally.

- **Interreligious dialogue (IRD)**

Interreligious dialogue (IRD) is best defined as intentional encounter and interaction among members of different religions as members of different religions. IRD refers to relations between believers of differing religions such as Christians, Jews, Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists, and followers of Traditional Religions. In IRD, participants encounter one another as representatives of different religious traditions who act as representatives of their respective religions. The effort does not aim at bringing about unity of all religions in a kind a super religion. IRD is a meeting of people of differing religions, in an atmosphere of freedom and openness, in order to listen to the other, to try to understand that person's religion, and hopefully to seek possibilities of collaboration. IRD happens every day, in the *trotro*, in taxis, at the market place, work place, at school and at all places where an encounter with other believers takes place.

- **Intra-faith Encounter/Ecumenism (I-FE/E)**

Intra-faith encounter (I-FE) or ecumenism (E) refers to all initiatives – prayers, meetings, dialogues, common projects, discussions etc. involving people of the different denominations within the same religion – to promote the reunion of all believers in that religion. For us Christians it is that initiative to promote the reunion of all Christians in one Church according to the will of Christ, the Founder. In Joh 17:21 Christ prayed “that all may be one”. It is in response to this and many other theological reasons that Christians try to engage one another in fraternal way in dialogue of all kinds in order to live in unity. Ecumenism is thus a Christian initiative to achieve the original purpose of Christ – the Messiah – i.e. that all, who believe in Christ, may be one. Strictly speaking, therefore, the term ecumenism refers specifically to attempts to promote unity and cooperation between Christian religious communities or churches. Other religions may have ecumenical encounters in their own right promote peace and unity within that religion as well.

The Context of IRD

A religiously plural world: We are living in religious plural world and Ghana is not an exception. Many religions that for some twenty years were non-existent in Ghana are spring up all over Africa today. The far eastern religions, Hinduism, Buddhism and various traditional religions are gaining adherents in Africa today. We are living with Muslims, traditionalists, and many other forms. We cannot ignore the need to talk, to relate and to share our God-giving life and destiny with others. We must share our values, beliefs, our philosophies with others to enrich them and also to enrich ourselves. IRD is *conditio sine qua non*. If properly done, IRD can help reduce fanaticism, barbaric acts perpetuated in the name of religion and help each other's religion in a decent and polite way.

A claim to religious superiority: In world where there is increasingly competition for religious superiority in order to win the hearts and minds of many new converts, there is the need to dialogue in order to share equitably the sacred space of our world today. A claim to religious superiority cannot be good response to diversity. Accepting the fact of otherness is more natural and sustainable effort in world of increasing diversity in opinion, values and taste.

A world of religious conflicts: In a world of rampant religious conflicts, conflicts often fuelled by religious beliefs directly or indirectly, there is the need to talk to each other to foster peace and coexistence in order to advance lasting human development. Conflicts of all kind have

never been an answer to disagreements of all forms. In this context, a good response lies in dialogue with believers as well as with the religions themselves. This is the way forward.

Globalization and its effects: Trade, Tourism and Sports and many other events of common interest are bringing people more closely than ever. All these people come with their religious and cultural backgrounds. To achieve peace and cooperation in the midst of this global context, there must be dialogue to facilitate acceptance, respect and understanding of one another's religion and the willingness to share our diverse but rich religious experiences.

Dialogue:

Without dialogue between people of faith, the vacuum in communication and understanding can quickly and easily be filled by gossip, mistrust, prejudice, bigotry and racism. Bigotry is fed by fear and ignorance. Without dialogue and mutual respect, extremism and hatred can grow. Tempers can flare and violent conflict would be the consequence. A proper approach will embrace learning about what adherents of a particular world faith say about their own faith rather than relying on what is alleged by others on their behalf. And that can take place only through dialogue. When interfaith co-operation works well, all of our lives are enriched. The knowledge and understanding of others enhances our lives, helps us to understand differences, gives substance to our belief and points us towards lives rooted and grounded in love. The basic idea behind dialogue is self-communication to others – which is in a Christian sense divine. Because God communicated his very being to us through the *logos* – word (*dialogos*). Thus, when we participate in dialogue, we at the same time partake in a divine act!! We become sharers of his being and fulfil our vocation to him as sons and daughters. We bring the imprint of God – the *imago Dei* (“image of God”) into our very actions.

What IFD/IRD is not

1. The IFD or IRD is not the same as the study of various religions and a comparison of them, although such a discipline is important and useful. Any act of comparing the religions involved in any form of dialogue encounter should be subdued.
2. It is also not a debate between followers of various religions, no matter how friendly. All attempts to impress others must be suppressed. IFD/IRD is all about sharing one's religion with others. In all dialogue encounters one should not try to prove oneself right and the other believer wrong.
3. It is also not an effort to persuade the other person to embrace one's own religion, although we cannot deny to any believer the right to wish to share one's religion with another.

What IRD or IFD is

It is an effort to share without conflict the sacred space(s) through dialogue among people of differing religions. With sacred space we are referring “to the field of the divine” – the spiritual realm – which is shared by all these religions. God cannot be a property of any one religion. No one religion can claim to possess the **divine space** – all religions have a share in it. IRD is an attempt to listen and understand one another through sharing of one another's faith.

It is also an effort to accept our common origin: The argument is simple: If indeed God created the world and all that is in it and that human beings are children of God (or *Allah*, *Nyame*, *Yahweh*, as he may be referred to in other religions), then we all belong, to a very

large extent, to God, whose image and imprint we bear. This connection to the **sacred** and **divine** must not be made to belong to one particular group. It must be shared! Through listening to others we can understand better our uniqueness, our common origin as humans, our shared responsibility and our common mission to make the presence of God be felt in our midst. Through listening to each other we can have a fruitful dialogue encounter. Willingness to listen always implies appreciation of what the other person is, believes, prays or lives, together with a conviction that it is worthwhile sacrificing some time to be informed about all that. The person who is very willing to talk but not so prepared to listen is not likely to be a good dialogue partner.

IRD is a kind of hospitality. Through dialoguing with others one becomes inclusive rather than exclusive. This is where we talk of hospitality. Extending the hand to others of differing religious we show hospitality; we show friendliness and offer people a room in our lives and faith to feel good.

Exclusivists view:

Some Christian exclusivists often point to scriptures for support to make nonsense out of the whole idea of dialogue: Mk 16:15-6 – “Go out to the whole world, proclaim the good news to all creation. He who believes and is baptized will be saved. He who does not believe will be condemned”. They cite from another place, “I am the way, I am the life. No one comes to the Father except by Me” (Joh 14:6). Others also cite Acts 4:12 in support of their exclusive views, where it says, “There is no salvation in anyone else at all, for there is no other name under heaven granted to man by which we may receive salvation”.

However, this same scripture says, ***“Love your neighbour as yourself”*** Who is then my neighbour – a catholic? I don’t think so! A neighbour could be anybody – a Samaritan, a Catholic, Christian, Muslim, Jew or a Hindu. The story of the Good Samaritan is model for Christian attitude towards people of deferring religions (Lk 10:25-37).

Lecture Week 2

Topic to be discussed: **Forms of Dialogue and Opportunities for Dialogue**

- ◇ Introduction
- ◇ Various forms of dialogue
 - ≡ Dialogue of Life
 - ≡ Dialogue of Action
 - ≡ Dialogue of Discourse
 - ≡ Dialogue of Experience
- ◇ Opportunities for Dialogue
 - Common problems:
 - Globalization
 - Locational coincidence:
 - Sports:
 - Fashion:
 - Education:
 - Tourism
 - Marriage
 - Religious Festivals
 - Political, Ideological Union etc

Various Forms of Dialogue

IRD can take different forms. Four major types of dialogue have been identified by dialogue experts without any suggestion that one form is necessarily superior to another.

Dialogue of Life

It is the form of IRD most within the reach of anyone who lives or interacts with believers in a different religion. Strictly speaking, this is an interfaith dialogue. Dialogue of life is interreligious relationship at the level of the ordinary relational situations of daily life: family, school, place of social or cultural contact, village meetings, workshops, workplace, politics, trade, commerce, working partners. This is indirect form of sharing faith which takes place between people of differing religions. When neighbours of differing religions are open to one another, when they share their projects and hopes, concerns and sorrows, they are engaging in dialogue of life. They do not necessarily discuss religion. But they draw on the values of their different beliefs and traditions.

This is where people strive to live in an open and neighbourly spirit, the ordinary everyday business of getting on with each other, of being good neighbours and living in peace and harmony. This can be hard enough for a people of a common background but, where religious and cultural differences exist, more effort is needed. There will be a need to make an effort to reach out, to understand, to break down our own prejudices and to overcome the barriers, stereotypes and suspicions that are in us all. This will not be easy and it will require perseverance. We will have to be patient, be willing to listen and to accept that people are different, or have a world-view different from our own. To live in peace as our faith requires demands this effort.

Dialogue of Action

This refers to people of differing beliefs cooperating for the promotion of human development and liberation in all its forms. Joint projects for human advancement can take the forms of building and running of joint projects such as construction of borehole, clinic, schools, creating common job opportunities, women of different beliefs joining hands to rescue other women, formation of a joint action to protect the environment in an area ravaged by drought,

famine, and poverty. Cooperating and working together to ensure that the rights and dignity of all people, for example those on the move (migrants) and their families if separated, are respected and upheld no matter who these people are or wherever they may be found is another example of dialogue of action.

Christians and Muslims in Ghana or anywhere they find themselves can work together to promote and preserve peace, liberty, social justice and moral values. Both faiths place a strong emphasis on justice and peace and on respect for human dignity. Both religions see human beings as stewards of God's creation, entrusted with the care of the earth. We share common concern for humanitarian values, the environment and for the proper use of the world's resources. We should, therefore, collaborate in addressing social concerns based on these common religious motives and values. On a local level, we can work together to build better communities, and to provide voluntary services and facilities. Issues of social concern such as housing, drug abuse, street violence, unemployment, refugees and education are areas where Muslims and Christians can cooperate.

We can all engage in the *Dialogue of Life* and the *Dialogue of Common Action*. These require no special expertise, but they do require an openness to interact with others in a spirit of respect and cooperation. These kinds of dialogue are important because they have a direct bearing on our daily lives and on how believers of differing religions live together in the now multicultural and multi-religious world. The *Dialogue of Life* and *of Common Action* can take place in both formal and informal settings. Informally, involvement in residents' associations, parent-teacher meetings, youth groups and sport clubs and all others forms of informal engagements of people of differing religions constitute dialogue of life or action accordingly. It can happen between individuals, neighbours, friends and people we work with. All of these are occasions where mutual understanding and an appreciation of the other can grow. Faith may not even be discussed in these situations, but it can be witnessed to through action, respect and mutual support. Individually, our involvement in the Dialogue of Life is very much about our attitude to each other and our disposition towards engaging with each other. Most forms of dialogue of action can be described as formal even though it is at the level of the ordinary life. This notwithstanding, some dialogues of action are informal. Rescue efforts of all kinds, where people do not formally agree but quickly jump to pursue a common, either for life-saving reasons otherwise, can be cited as good examples of informal action.

Dialogue of Discourse

This takes place on academic or official levels between experts, theologians and religious leaders. In other words, with dialogue of Discourse we think of experts in Christianity and other religions meeting to exchange information on their respective religious beliefs and heritages. They listen to each other in an effort to understand the religion of the others at a deeper level as articulated by qualified and well-prepared representatives of those religious traditions. They try to see what beliefs and practices they share in common and where they differ. Together they try to face modern problems and challenges in the light of their differing religions. This type of dialogue, of its nature, is for specialists. This kind of dialogue helps to clarify issues, to create greater understanding and remove prejudices. By establishing links and relationships between leaders, such dialogue can facilitate and enable practical cooperation and action on the other levels described below. The aim of this exchange is not to reach a common belief, but rather to clarify what each partner believes, to appreciate each other's spiritual values and to have a better understanding of differences.

Dialogue on this level has been happening for many years in many places around the world, and has helped to increase understanding and cooperation. Unfortunately much of the good has been undone by the polarization of the various religions taking place due to fanaticism, violence and socio-political unrest. More dialogue, not less, is needed to counter these

negative trends. In most places around world, dialogue between religious leaders is only just beginning and is a welcome development. The engagement of religious leaders in the dialogue process gives both encouragement and an example for people of both faiths to follow. An example of such dialogue would be a formation of groups of experts of differing religions that do theological studies on pertinent questions or issues together.

Dialogue of Religious Experience

Dialogue of religious experience refers to persons deeply rooted in their own religious traditions sharing experiences of meditation, prayer, contemplation, faith and its expression, ways of searching for God as the Absolute or of living the monastic or eremitic life, and also mysticism. This form of exchange is for persons who are committed to a more than ordinary pursuit of spiritual progress. There are *de facto* Catholic (Benedictine and Trappist) monks who have carefully planned inter-monastic exchanges with Buddhist counterparts. Such communications generally include several weeks' stay in the monastery of the other in silence and in the sharing of what is possible and advisable. It must be noted that the above forms of dialogue do not exclude one another, that no one is expected to practice all forms in all circumstances, but that whenever a believer meets another of a different religious conviction, at least one form of dialogue is possible.

This involves interfaith prayer and also occasions when spirituality and religious texts are studied by members of both faiths. This kind of dialogue also requires a level of expertise. Great care needs to be taken when preparing a Muslim Christian prayer service (or any interfaith event). It is important that there is a real reason or need for the shared prayer: for example, when something significant happens in local communities calling for people to come together in prayer.

It is difficult to find forms of joint prayer that respect the sensibilities of both Muslims and Christians for example. Interfaith Prayer events often take the form of each participant listening respectfully to the prayer of the other. Silent reflection is also a powerful symbol. When preparing an interfaith prayer event the guiding principle should be that of respecting the beliefs of the other. All preparation should be done jointly with texts, words, symbols, actions and music discussed and agreed. Having a practice "dry run" of the planned event is a good idea as it will give all those organizing the event a clear idea of what will happen, thus avoiding unforeseen and avoidable causes of offence or embarrassment. Once a format and Order of Service has been agreed, stick to it.

Major opportunities for Dialogue

Common problems: Common problems of today's religions such as secularism, fanaticism, relativism, moral decadence, wars, poverty, social disintegration and social media revolution and its challenges to faith etc. must be seen as opportunity to come together in search of common solutions. Believers of differing religions cannot address common challenges if they remain sectarian.

Globalization: Globalization offers our religious groups a great opportunity today to try to understand each other's religion. The world today is constantly in motion through internet and social media revolution. The world is a global village. People of differing religions are reaching out physically through tourism, trade and various exchange programmes. Virtually, the distance between people, cultures and religious traditions is becoming shorter and shorter through the social media revolution. The world is gradually recognizing the need to engage itself in dialogue. This is a huge opportunity for our world religions to communicate themselves in a succinct manner possible to enable them share their rich faith traditions with other religions.

Locational coincidence: Coincidentally people of differing religions encounter each other in different ways and at different locations on flights, in buses, on holidays, at conferences, business meetings, theatre centres, international sport arenas, as business partners, as colleagues etc. These occasions must be seen as an opportunity for collaborative cooperation especially in interreligious sense. This cooperation could be formal and informal.

Sports: Sport today is offering people an opportunity to accept each other in spirit of friendship and brotherhood. Fans across the globe identify with particular clubs and individuals are being bounded together by such clubs. Even fans of differing clubs and individuals understand the nature of sports and often, but not always, engage themselves in friendly manner. Within any fan base are people of differing religions, who suspend their religious opinions and engage in certain form of dialogue.

Fashion: Fashion today is drawing inspiration from many religious products. The rosary for instance is becoming a “fashionable necklace” acceptable and admired by the youth. Today, the Thobe is being worn by Muslims and non-Muslims alike. This is wonderful development and mark of acceptance and identification on one hand and the tolerance on the other. This must be viewed as an opportunity to bring the religions into dialogue with the world today.

Education: Today, university and college campuses are emerging as critical spaces for the advancement of interfaith and interreligious dialogue. As Ghana grows more diverse culturally and religiously, institutions of higher learning have a key role to play in building knowledge and promoting the exchange of ideas. Students have taken the lead in developing new initiatives that engage commonalities and differences across traditions and advance collaboration around issues of democracy and social justice on campus, across the country, and around the world. Education in general offers a huge opportunity to engage in dialogue of discourse through learning and sharing common values.

Tourism: As a result of the economic development and growing standards of living and the growing income levels across the globe, more and more people are having extra reserves for relaxation. People are constantly on the move visiting tourist attractions centres around the globe. These people come from various religious backgrounds and bring with them their religious traditions. When they meet and befriend others from other religious backgrounds they engage in form of dialogue.

Marriages: Intercultural and most especially interreligious marriages offer the world religions of today a huge opportunity to engage in dialogue of all forms. Couples of differing religious backgrounds can benefit a lot from dialoguing.

Religious festivals: Christmas, Easter, Eid Al-Fitr and Eid Al-Adha etc offer Muslims and Christians the world over the opportunity to share their joy and rich traditional heritage with others through participation in the festivals and the exchange of gifts that are associated with them.

Opportunities for dialogue are many. This course is one such opportunity! In many cases it will depend on how the student argues his point out. Even this course offers not only students the opportunity for dialogue but also people they will be interacting with can share in this opportunity. Surely changing attitudes towards otherness in general can have multiple effects on the lives of many. Students are therefore encouraged to discover the various opportunity for dialogue in and around them and make use of them to reach out to others.

Lecture Weeks 3&4: Necessity of Interfaith and Interreligious Dialogue

It is now imperative to face directly the question: Is interreligious dialogue really necessary? Granted that it is a suitable pursuit for university eggheads and ivory-tower theologians, but can a busy religious leader, bishop, priest, lawyer, doctor, or industrialist really afford the time for this? How is the ordinary citizen in the crowded city, or the poor village farmer, to be convinced of the urgency of interreligious dialogue?

Areas of Concern

⇒ **The Natural Reasons for IRD**

- ◇ Unity of Human Nature
- ◇ Common World

⇒ **Other Important Reasons for IRD**

- ◇ Religious Plurality
- ◇ Desire for Interaction
- ◇ Mutual Enrichment
- ◇ Interaction and Mutual Enrichment of Religions
- ◇ Harmony Between Citizens
- ◇ Joint Promotion of Moral Values, Development, Justice, and Peace
- ◇ Solutions to Religious Extremism

⇒ **Religious Reasons for IRD**

- ◇ Christian Reasons
 - The Trinity Faith
 - Jesus' Self-emptying
- ◇ Islamic Reason
 - Islamic Middle Nation notion
- ◇ African Traditional Reason
 - The Belief in Lesser Gods

▪ **The Natural Reasons for IRD**

UNITY OF HUMAN NATURE:

The first natural reason for the necessity of interreligious relations is the unity of human nature. It is God who created every man and woman. Human nature is shared equally by all. Each human being is essentially body and soul, matter and spirit, a being gifted with intelligence and will. More important still, every human being has a desire, hidden or open, for a transcendent God. And people have right to have such a desire, irrespective of their geographical area. And everyone notices his or her inability to reach this transcendent God, if totally unaided. In the religions people look for an aid to reach this transcendent God. Since by nature people are different, people find also in different ways different fulfilment and answers to their problems. Such differences of fulfilment are in our nature and must not be exploited to disrupt natural human endeavour. In nature there is always equilibrium. Since human beings belong to this natural world with its equilibrium, human beings must use their special and natural gift to dialogue to resolve differences to achieve and sustain the unity of the human race. All of us belong to one extended family – the human race.

In the various religions, people are seeking answers to the fundamental questions that have tormented human existence in all ages. Among them are questions about human origin and destiny, the essence of happiness, the meaning of evil and sin, the reason for suffering and especially, that Being who explains all other beings. Here as above some religions have put

together what the human soul looking for God and for answers to the above questions has been able to arrive at. Some religions believe that they have received explicit revelations from God in one form or another. It is true there are wide differences between the religions. But it is also true that there are convergences or at least analogies. If for no other reasons, then at least because of the unity of human nature, the followers of the religions of the world should meet, listen to another, try to understand one another, and see what they can do together. That is what interreligious dialogue is all about.

COMMON WORLD:

All religions must see themselves as neighbours living in one world. It is this one world in which our common origin, nature and destiny derive their meaning and importance. As neighbours we must first accept that we must coexist, cooperate and collaborate with one another to defend and protect, to transform and sustain, and to transfer peacefully the world to future generations. No particular religion can deprive the other of its place in this common world. The world belongs to none but all of us. Religious violence on the assumption of being the only religion in the world is inconsistent with the facts on the ground.

▪ Other Important Reasons

RELIGIOUS PLURALITY:

Plurality¹ as used here refers to diversity. Religious diversity is a fact. The signs of this phenomenon are identifiable everywhere. In the world of today this reality is being more increasingly brought to our notice. Christians form about 31.5% of the total world population. Of that figure, Catholics count for 17.5% and other Christians 14%. Muslims number 23.2%, Hindus 15%, Buddhists 7.1% and Jews 0.2%. But there are also Traditional or Folk Religionists, Sikhs, Jainists, Zoroastrians, Baha'is, Shintoists, and others. They account for about 5.9% of the world population. The unaffiliated (Secular/Nonreligious/Agnostic/Atheists) form about 15.35% of the world population. These religions are the ways of life of a greater part of humanity. They are the living expressions of the souls of vast groups of people. They carry with them the echo of thousands of years of humanity looking for God. And no matter what mistakes humanity may have made (and religious truth is not always easy to arrive at, and is even more difficult to live for long without special help from God), we cannot doubt the sincerity of heart and the moral and spiritual stature of many religious leaders along the corridors of history. Moreover, the world's religions possess an impressive patrimony of deeply religious texts and of the assimilated wisdom of peoples and cultures. The have taught generations of people how to pray, how to live, how to die, and how to look after their deceased ones (cf. *Evangelii Nuntiandi*, #53). It would be most unrealistic to ignore all this and live as if there were only one religion in the world. This fact calls for dialogue to accept other's religion for a peaceful coexistence.

DESIRE FOR INTERACTION:

In the world of our times, people of differing religions meet much more frequently than in past centuries. Opportunities for travel and for instant communications worldwide are now greater than in any other period of human history. People from Asia visit Europe and America

¹ Plurality as used here describes the phenomenon of existence of many religions in our world today. It is different from religious pluralism. Do not confuse these terms. Religious Pluralism refers to the approach or posture or attitude people adopt in response to the fact of religious diversity or plurality. And there are several approaches to the phenomenon of religious plurality. Three main ones include: **exclusivism**, **inclusivism** and **pluralism**. Others include **relativism** and **scepticism**. For more on meaning of these responses, see the *Excursus*.

or settle down to live in these continents in bigger numbers than ever before. Europeans and Americans go to Asia. The wide-bodied intercontinental jets are not lacking passengers. Africa and Europe know each other more than they ever did before. Oceania is not left out. The sciences of anthropology, ethnology, and religions have made tremendous progress. The term global village, as applied to a world in which communications are shortening distances, is not altogether an exaggeration.

It is not just the desire to travel that brings about this encounter, but also more serious circumstances. The upheavals brought about by famine and other natural disasters, by wars (Iraq, Syria) and internal conflicts, have displaced large numbers of people. Economic necessity also drives people to seek employment elsewhere. African young men and women, even pregnant women, nursing mothers travel long distances through dangerous circumstances to reach the shores of Europe in search for greener pastures. All this has added to increased contact between people of different religious traditions.

It is not only that people are meeting one another, bringing with them their cultures and religions. It is also that they want to meet. Isolationism is being frowned upon more and more. And in fact they have a right to move around and remove the artificial barriers of national and geographical borders of our world today. What people and religions have in common is being increasingly recognized as more important than what divides them. Religious believers want to be well informed about other religions whose adherents are now their neighbours or colleagues. They are no longer satisfied with labels and generalized judgements earlier passed on the entire religious family of the other. In short, they want interreligious relations.

MUTUAL ENRICHMENT:

Interreligious dialogue can help each participant to grow in his or her own faith when that partner in dialogue encounters a person of another religious persuasion and engages in sincere and calm confrontation of religious beliefs, practices, and values. Sometimes a religious conviction is better appreciated, further studied and deepened, understood and lived with greater commitment, when met with other views. Another religious believer can also challenge us in the best sense of the word. When you know, for example, that in Buddhist monasteries in Thailand and elsewhere Monks live strict ascetic lives: sleep on hard beds, eat only once a day, avoid meat and fish, and have the vow of celibacy, as a priest and as a Christian you are implicitly challenged to live with greater commitment the riches of Christian asceticism. When you notice that a sincere Muslim prays at stated times five times a day, and that he does not allow human respect to prevent him from doing this at any corner he finds himself within these times, then you avoid asking yourself why some Christians are hesitant to make the Sign of the Cross in a restaurant, or pray their Rosary in a bus, or to recite the Angelus in some other public places.

There is no doubt that a participant in interreligious dialogue, while remaining firmly rooted in his or her religion, can grow spiritually through interreligious encounters, on condition that the person remains open to the action of God, which can come through the dialogue partner. Interreligious dialogue benefits the individuals involved in various ways. It reduces prejudices, fosters better understanding and leads to a better appreciation of others.

INTERACTION AND MUTUAL ENRICHMENT OF RELIGIONS:

It is not only individual participants who can be enriched through interreligious contacts. It is also their religions themselves. Through interreligious contacts, for example, Christianity can contribute to other religions' elevation, inspiration, and universality. Christianity has helped some religions shed some of their unworthy beliefs and practices such as human sacrifice, the killing of twins and albinos, or the denial of some human rights to unborn children or to

women. It has helped Buddhism to show more interest in social work and initiatives toward human promotion. Buddhists and Muslims can see in Christianity a religion that gives women a higher status than theirs. Traditional religions can see in Christianity a fulfillment of many of their not fully articulated longings for contact with God, the Supreme Spirit. There is also the question of the relationship between religion, country, and culture. In some minority Buddhist and Islamic countries, there is the danger of identifying the country's culture with Buddhism or Islam. Examples are Thailand and some Arab countries. Some Hindus think that to be Indian is to be Hindu.

Christians, especially Catholics, bring to dialogue a universalism that is remarkable. The Church has unity in doctrine and in religious authority, but at the same time a firm belief in the right of the human person to religious freedom. And the church makes a serious effort to respect people's cultures, languages, ways of worship, and national character in the same family of faith. Indeed Christianity is really saying: God is our Father, and we are all brothers and sisters; let us hold hands together, let us work together, and make the world a better place in which to live. This message welcomed by many religions of the world. The desire of other believers to meet the Pope, to come to Rome, and to work with Catholics, even when they do not accept some major elements of Catholic faith and morals, is a sign of this appreciation and desire for an exchange of gifts.

Christianity also receives from the other religions when they meet. These religions bring along with them cultural pattern in which they flourish: languages, philosophical categories, ritual expressions and local styles proper to their peoples. They can enrich the expression and practice of Christianity with these gifts. In this sense interreligious dialogue can help to promote what has come to be known as inculturation in theological circles: the incarnation of Christianity among different peoples and cultures. The Second Vatican Council wisely noted that the Church fosters and takes to herself "in so far as they are good, the ability, resources and customs of each people. Taking them to herself, she purifies, strengthens and ennobles them. The Church in this is mindful that she must harvest with the King to whom the nations were given for an inheritance and into whose city they bring gifts and presents (*Lumen Gentium*, #13). The Church is aware of her call to universality and appreciates the fact that contact with other religions can help her to express this.

HARMONY BETWEEN CITIZENS:

If citizens of the same country or region belong to different religions, they can find in interreligious dialogue a help to build up and strengthen harmony in society. Acceptance of others, with all that differentiates them from one's own religious community, is very much a requirement of harmony. The alternative is to ignore one another, to label others with unacceptable generalizations, or worse still, to engage in rivalry, to foster tension, or to wade into violence.

Religion in itself is not the cause of fractions, violence and war. Every religion worthy of the name teaches the Golden Rule: to treat others as one would like to be treated. However, when religion is abused in order to motivate people to engage in violence, the results can be indeed negative. This can happen when the real motives of the promoters are economic, racial, political, or desires of revenge, or pure jealousy. This shows why religious leaders have the duty to show their coreligionists the genuine face of religion and to convince them that it is a contradiction of true religion to engage in violence. To kill others in the name of God or religion is a travesty of what genuine religion is all about.

Community leaders, statesmen, political figures and all citizens need to be convinced that the abuse or hijacking of religion in order to foment enmities and violence can cripple a community or country. Pope John Paul II drew the world's attention to the contribution of

interreligious relations to promote harmony when he spoke to distinguished representatives of many world religions gathered at the Assisi World Day of Prayer for Peace on Oct 27, 1986. And this is what he says: *“Either we learn to walk together in peace and harmony, or we drift apart and ruin ourselves and others. We hope that this pilgrimage to Assisi has taught us anew to be aware of the common origin and common destiny of humanity. Let us see in it an anticipation of what God would like the developing history of humanity to be: a fraternal journey in which we accompany one another towards the transcendent goal which he sets for us”*. (John Paul II: Concluding Address at Assisi, 95, in *Assisi World Day of Prayer for Peace*; Rome: Pontifical Commission “Justitia et Pax”, 1987, pp. 95-6)

JOINT PROMOTION OF MORAL VALUES, DEVELOPMENT, JUSTICE AND PEACE

When the followers of the various religions in a country or region not only live in harmony but also positively cooperate, then they can do much to promote moral values, development in all its forms, and more justice in society. They thus prepare the way for peace.

While a few people are enough to cause tension, confusion, and destruction, the cooperation of all is needed in order to promote lasting development, justice and peace. There are problems and challenges that do not respect religious frontiers: corruption in public life, wrong attitude to work or to the good of the country, and discrimination against people because of their colour, ethnic background, or sex, environmental degradation, deceit in the name of religion (fake pastors and Malams). There are development questions that no one religious community can solve single-handedly: uncontrolled urbanization, the growing gap between the rich and the poor, runaway inflation.

All these and similar challenges are best faced when all believers, drawing from the highest ideals of their respective religions, work together to find adequate solutions. After all, there is no separate Catholic draught, or Jewish epidemic, or Muslim urbanization, or Buddhist inflation, or Sikh poverty, or Hindu embezzlement of public funds. All these are problems and challenges of the whole society. Interreligious dialogue effort to face them is not optional. It is obligatory. Such collaboration is even more urgent when the problems are due to the human will: oppression of the poor, tribalism, religious discrimination, and erosion of sound family values.

SOLUTIONS TO RELIGIOUS EXTREMISM

More than one country is troubled by religious extremists. These are people who, in their desire to be faithful to what they consider to be the original and undiluted form of their religion, adopt extreme measures toward other believers, or even toward the more moderate members of their own religious community. They, for example, want all religions to be illegal in their country except their own religion, and to promote this they are ready even to kill. They sometimes insist on a particular article of clothing, for example, for women, and will use violence against those who do not comply. In one country they even made out a list of words that adherents of the other religions are not allowed to use.

Many of the major religions in the world have, or have had, religious extremists. Some are more violent than others. All of them are intolerant. The religious extremists, or fundamentalists as some call them, may be sincere and in good faith. But at the same time they are trampling on the rights of others. They are violating the principle of religious freedom, which says that one is to use force on another human being in matters of conscience, in matters religious. Religion should well up from the human soul as a free offering to God, as a free response of the human creature to God the Creator.

All genuine religious leaders, as well as thoughtful civil authorities, are worried by the phenomenon of religious extremism. Interreligious relations can, and should, help to moderate the “zeal” of the extremists, to convince them to accommodate others, beginning with the

more moderate members of their own religion, and to lead them to forge their swords into farm instruments to build up and not to pull down.

Religious Reasons for IRD

Notwithstanding the reasons mentioned above, there are also some important reasons why IRD cannot in our world today be optional. These reasons are imbedded in the religions themselves in their theological fabric and practices. A discussion about the reasons why IRD cannot be optional cannot be held without taking note of these religious fundamental reasons. Below are a summary of some such reasons.

CHRISTIAN REASONS

Trinitarian Faith: For Christians the Trinitarian theology offers one of the most if not the most compelling argument for why IRD cannot be optional. The Trinitarian faith expresses a belief in the Godhead as being of three persons in one God (God the Father; God the Son; and God the Holy Spirit), who are equal in substance but distinctly three persons. Father is God; Son is God; Holy Spirit is God. In the Trinity, Christians believe that the Father is not the Son and the Son is not the Father and the Holy Spirit is neither the Father nor the Son. These distinct persons have been revealed to us through the Son. They are in constant dialogue with one another especially in their relationship with humanity. They have an indwelling nature dancing so to say in themselves without any problems. Christians by nature should at all times resemble their God; sharing this dialogic nature of their God with humanity. In dialogue with people of other religions Christians bear witness to the Trinitarian God.

Jesus' Self-emptying love: Out of love for humanity Christ as we read from the Letter of St Paul to the Philippians though was in the form of God did not count equality a thing to be grasped. He emptied himself and took our human form... (Phil 2:5f. The Christian has a vocation to imitate Christ in this manner by sharing his being with others. This is one of the essentials of every dialogue encounter. This offers the Christian a compelling argument that dialogue with people of otherness is an act of self-emptying for the edification of others and all.

The Logos idea: The incarnation of the logos (the word becoming flesh) as expressed in the Gospel of John (John 1:1-18) is another Christian theology points out the importance of dialogue to the Christian. God in his infinite wisdom has communicated himself to us through the Logos – word and has made by this very act the whole idea of *dia-logos* a divine act. Whenever a Christian engages in dialogue of any form, he or she participates in this divine act of communicating himself to us through the instrument of his word. Through the instrument of a word people of differing religious share with others their precious beliefs as well as experiences with the divine. By so doing they participate in the divine life for the edification of the world and unity of all.

ISLAMIC REASON

Islamic middle Nation theology: In one verse in the Quran it is said: “And thus we have appointed you as a middle nation, that you may be witnesses over other people.” (Quran 2:143). Thus, for Muslims, Allah has chosen the Islamic religion inheritor of the prophetic message. Through them God reaches out to others who are non-Muslims. This enjoins on Muslims to engage with others in order to fulfil this mission. They have a vocation to engage others. This is a reason why perhaps IRD cannot also be optional to the believers of Islam.

TRADITIONAL BELIEF IN THE ROLE OF THE LESSER GODS

According to the traditional belief found in most African traditional religions lesser gods of various forms are constantly at the service of the Supreme Being. They sometimes act on his behalf to avert danger and bring prosperity to their followers on his behalf as well. The Supreme Being shares his being with other lesser deities and cooperates with them in dealing with human beings. Such a belief in lesser deities of varied form and nature can be a good foundation of engaging the problem of otherness in religious traditions. God communicates himself differently and through varied beings sharing faith and coexisting with people of different religious backgrounds is nothing new but part of the basic belief system of the African traditional religion.

EXCURSUS: RELIGIOUS PLURALISM

Religious pluralism, broadly construed, is a response to the diversity of religious beliefs, practices, and traditions that exist both in the contemporary world and throughout history. The term “diversity” refers here to the phenomenal fact of the variety of religious beliefs, practices, and traditions. Some scholars refer to this phenomenon as “religious plurality”. The terms “pluralism” refer to one form of response to such diversity. Other responses are “exclusivism” and “inclusivism”.

Exclusivist positions maintain that only one set of beliefs, claims or practices can ultimately be true or correct (in most cases, those of the one holding the position). A Christian exclusivist would therefore hold that the beliefs of non-Christians (and perhaps even Christians of other denominations) are in some way flawed, if not wholly false; or that non-Christian religious practices are not ultimately efficacious – at least, to the extent that non-Christian beliefs and practices depart from or conflict with those defended by the Christian exclusivist. In other words only his religion holds the truth. Such views can lead to religious fanaticism.

Pluralist positions, in contrast, argue that more than one set of beliefs or practices can be, at least partially and perhaps wholly, true or correct simultaneously – or, that all beliefs intended to be understood in a realist fashion are false. Such views can lead to religious syncretism which is considered in Christian circles as an apostasy.

Inclusivist positions occupy a middle ground between exclusivism and pluralism, insofar as they recognize the possibility that more than one religious tradition can contain elements that are true or efficacious, while at the same time hold that only one tradition expresses ultimate religious truth most completely. Inclusivists grant that many (perhaps all) religious traditions do well in regards to truth or salvation, but that one tradition does better than others by more accurately describing objects of belief or mechanisms of salvation. A Christian inclusivist might claim that those who live good lives but remain non-Christians may still achieve salvation, but that such salvation is nevertheless still achieved through Jesus Christ. Inclusivism thus may be understood as a more charitable variety of exclusivism, though exclusivists can also treat it as pluralism by another name. In addition, it is worth noting that exclusivist, inclusivist, or pluralist arguments about beliefs are sometimes presented separately from those about salvific practice and that consequently one approach to diversity of belief does not necessarily imply the same approach to diversity of practice, or vice versa. There remain a few other possible positions outside of exclusivism, inclusivism, and pluralism that are worth mentioning briefly, though two of these are not commonly treated as sophisticated options in philosophical discussions of religious diversity. The first of these two is **relativism**: the view that the truths of beliefs or the efficacy of practices are wholly dependent on the perspective of the religious individual and her cultural environment. In other words, relativism is the philosophical position that all points of view are equally valid and that all truth is relative to the individual. This means that all moral positions, all religious systems, all art

forms, all political movements, etc., are truths that are relative to the individual. Under the umbrella of relativism, whole groups of perspectives are categorized. In obvious terms, some are: *cognitive relativism* (truth) - *Cognitive relativism* affirms that all truths are relative. This would mean that no system of truth is more valid than another one, and that there is no objective standard of truth. It would, naturally, deny that there is a God of absolute truth. *Moral/ethical relativism* - All morals are relative to the social group within which they are constructed. *Situational relativism* – Situational relativism holds for example that ethics (right and wrong) are dependent upon the situation. Unfortunately, the philosophy of relativism is pervasive in our culture today. However, because individuals and cultural environments change with time, such a view will subject truths to the force of change. The limitation of truths to the individual or its environment is problem of relativism. The second, which would have similar consequences, is the position that no positive religious beliefs are true in any sense, even the relativist ones, and no religious practices are efficacious (at least not according to their own terms). In this case, which may be termed **strong anti-realism**, religious diversity remains at most a sociological, psychological, or historical topic. This is atheism. Another position, that of **skepticism**, seems to entertain this possibility insofar as it concedes that some set of religious claims may be true.

Key Components of Dialogue of any Form

Under this subheading we want to study what are some key components of dialogue. There are some key ingredients that must be part of every dialogue encounter, without which the entire idea of interfaith and inter religious dialogue will be rendered meaningless. Below are some few key points of exceptional importance.

Openness to Dialogue

By engaging in any form of dialogue, participants are positioned to encounter views and experiences that differ from their own. In many cases, this new information may prompt people to reconsider and perhaps even alter their own perspectives and beliefs. Being open to this kind of personal transformation involves being self-aware of one's own views and willing to intentionally listen to the experiences of another group. Individuals' openness to this kind of transformation is key to successful dialogue encounter. A dialogue partner at every time must be someone who is open to people of other religions. In a dialogue devoid of openness, lies, deception and mistrust will fill the vacuum. There will be in the end confusion, misconceptions and finally dialogue will fail.

Willingness to Share

In dialogue, participants communicate themselves, their cherished religious ideals; in fact they share their very selves with others. Without that willingness to share with others what one believes dialogue of all kinds will be just a show. The willingness to share could be an important motivation even for good as a preparation for dialogue of experience and of theological discourse. In this way dialogue encounters can be viewed as gesture of hospitality – sharing with joy one's cherished faith is always a matter of willingness.

Ability to Listen

A dialogue partner must have at all times the willingness and in fact the ability to listen to people of other opinions. This is a key ingredient of tolerance. Without a listening heart tolerance is impossible to achieve. In fact, it is the foundation of every dialogue engagement. Without the ability and also the willingness to listen, dialogue of all kinds is rendered useless and to a large extent made meaningless and impossible.

Mutual Respect

Without mutual respect, people will not first have any good reason to dialogue. Dialogue partners must always act with respect towards people of differing religion. Mutual respect will then mature and bear the fruit of acceptance. It is through mutual respect that the doors of other religions will be opened for fruitful engagement.

Lecture Weeks 5&6: The Risks of Interreligious Dialogue

What shall we reply to a person who argues thus: “I accept all that has been said in the preceding lectures. I see the point that interreligious dialogue is not optional in the world of today. But I consider it dangerous. I have seen it do harm to some of my coreligionists. It is risky. Danger of losing one’s faith, relativism, syncretism, and religious indifferentism are some of the risks.” We have to admit that most of these concerns are real. This should not make us run away from a dialoguing with one another. Let us look at the following considerations into details.

Areas of Concern

- ⇒ Danger of Losing One’s Faith
- ⇒ Risk of Relativism
- ⇒ Fear of Syncretism
- ⇒ Fear of the Flock Seeking Pastures Elsewhere
- ⇒ Danger of Religious Indifferentism

■ DANGER OF LOSING ONE’S FAITH

Some people fear that in interreligious dialogue they may meet other believers who are theologically better prepared than themselves, more sophisticated, and better able to articulate their religious beliefs and practices. Or the religion of the other person may be better structured institutionally and armed with more personnel, centers for higher religious studies, and hard cash. Some fear a religion they regard as politically powerful. The overall risk, the argument goes, is that the “weaker” partner in dialogue may become confused, may be theologically overpowered, and may be imperceptibly wheeled into religious doubt, or into abandoning his or her religion and embracing that of the more “powerful” dialogue partner.

The answer is that interreligious dialogue need not take the form of theological discussion at all. It may just be what was called *dialogue of life* we saw at the beginning of our lectures, or cooperation in social projects – dialogue of action. Moreover, even when it is a question of theological dialogue, it is not advisable for a believer who is theologically unprepared to meet a theology professor from another religion. A certain parity of cultural and educational background is required for fair and fruitful theological exchange.

In all cases, whether for the learned or for the less articulate, it most important that one should be sincerely convinced of one’s own faith and deeply grounded in it before one can fruitfully and without undue risk meet people of a different religious conviction.

■ RISK OF RELATIVISM

Others fear that to meet other believers often can cause such erosion in one’s religious tenets that finally a person end up believing that one religion is as good as another. Tis the error of religious relativism, the mistake of those who say that all religions are roads to the same God, and that it does not matter to what religion a person chooses to belong, as long as the person has good will.

Let us distinguish between sincerity and objectivity. Sincerity is very important especially in religious matters, because good will, good conscience, honesty, lack of deceit, and freedom from duplicity are fundamental religious requirements. But objectivity is no less important, since everyone is bound to look for the objective religious truth and, having found it, the

person is bound to embrace it. And every person will have to answer before God for all religious choices. This is one of the reasons for the principle of religious liberty.

To the error of religious relativism we therefore reply that one religion is not as good as another, that the religions are not all saying the thing on every point at issue, and that every individual has personal responsibility, and therefore freedom, to look for objective religious truth. This clear mind about the existence of objective truth, allied with respect for everyone's religion even when one disagrees with some aspects of it, is a necessary requirement for safe and fruitful interreligious dialogue.

▪ FEAR OF SYNCRETISM

An allied fear to relativism is that of syncretism. Syncretism is the effort to put several religions together and to carve a new religion out of them. The effort may be guided by the desire to preserve all the factors that seem common denominator. It may be the desire not to offend any of the believers but rather to work out a pattern in which none of them feels threatened.

It is not often that people would propose syncretism in theory as new religion. Nevertheless, some have de facto engaged in syncretism by pulling, for example, some Christian beliefs into African Traditional Religion with Africa or in Latin America or vice versa. Others have coined "new religions" in Europe by mixing up elements of Hinduism and Buddhism with Christianity and ancient pre-Christian religions.

Syncretism may more often appear in particular practices such as interreligious prayer, when it does not respect the religious identity of the participants but presents them as members of one religious community of faith. There can also be examples of ritual, religious dress, religious titles, or building styles over which even believers in one religion can disagree whether there is really syncretism, or whether they are only instances of adaptation, or inculturation, or indigenization of one or other religion.

Syncretism is a danger that has to be watched in interreligious relations. No attempt should be made to nibble at the religious identity of any of the participants.

At the same time, the necessity of a religion that lays claim of universality to seek to be at home among all peoples and cultures cannot be denied. The Catholic Church, for example, believes that it is in her very nature to be at home in every culture. Not even the fear of possible syncretism will discourage her from efforts at inculturation. Theologians and pastors should rather exercise their office of clarification, guidance, vigilance.

▪ FEAR OF THE FLOCK SEEKING PASTURES ELSEWHERE

Some religious leaders are hesitant to encourage their coreligionists to make friends with people of other religions because they fear that their flock may seek more satisfying pastures elsewhere. Some bishops and priests in Europe, for example, are noticing that some of their Christians, especially from among the young, are falling in love with some elements of Hinduism, Buddhism, Shintoism, or some other oriental religions. They are fascinated by Oriental methods of meditation. They are sitting at the feet of Japanese *roshis* and Indian gurus. They are practicing *yoga* and *Zen*. Some are flying to Asian countries to make direct contact with these religions at their sources. There are many US and European Christians who have become Buddhist monks and nuns in Thailand and Taiwan.

The risk is real. But it applies rather to the type of Christian who is not well grounded in the Christian faith and practice. Unfortunately there are many especially among the young, who are abysmally ignorant of the major tenets of Christianity. They do not know about the riches of Christian asceticism or mysticism. For them, St. Teresa of Avila, St. John of the Cross, St.

Catherine of Siena, St. Francis of Assisi, and St. Theresa of the Holy Child Jesus are mere names whose spiritualities are largely a closed book to them.

Christian pastors who have such religiously rootless Christians have to ask themselves to what extent they have helped their coreligionists to make progress in personal or mental prayer. Have the youth found in their pastors spiritual masters at the feet of whom they have learned how to pray, and not just how to read prayers already printed out, no matter the irreplaceable necessity of fixed liturgical prayer? Moreover, Catholic monasteries can ask themselves whether the surrounding Catholic community sees in them centres of silence in searching for the face of God, sacred places for initiation into contemplation or prayer of the heart, and seedbeds of mysticism. And Christian families can ask themselves how much religious instruction, family prayer, and family reception of the sacraments are to be found in their homes.

If young Christians are maimed by religious ignorance of the riches of Christian life and mysticism, and are tormented by spiritual hunger for some elevating spiritual practices, is it any wonder if they go spiritual shopping among Oriental religions, or even among the sects, new religious movements, or esoteric groups? This is the explanation for the reason why the young are drifting away to other religions.

■ DANGER OF RELIGIOUS INDIFFERENTISM

There is also the fear that frequent contact with people of other religious convictions may lead some believers to lose belief in any one religion. They may begin by putting some beliefs of their religion in parentheses, by suspending their belief in some tenets for more time. This is already a sign that there is a problem. But they may move on to a general doubt about their own religion and then about every other religion. Some of such religious indifferentists try to justify their position by presenting themselves as liberal, or as broad-minded as opposed to fanatical, or simply as post-Christian.

Such a position is erroneous because there is such a thing as objective religious truth not based on people's opinions. Every teacher knows that sincerity is not only a virtue required of the student. Knowledge of the objective truth and ability to state it are also necessary.

Religious indifferentism can be avoided in interreligious contacts if the participants are well grounded in their own religions, if they live these religions with sincerity and authenticity, if they are well adjusted to their faith community, and if their religious community takes an interest in their interreligious contacts.

So, there are real risks involved in interreligious dialogue. But they are not unavoidable. The worst fears need not be realized. And the best results can be obtained, if only the necessary steps are taken. Everyone who rides a bicycle or drives a car understands this. The adequate answer to possible risks is not to renounce the whole exercise but to ride or drive carefully.

EXCURSUS: SYNCRETISM

The word came from the Latin *syncretismus* inspired by the Greek word *synkretismos*. The etymology of the word is, however, not certain. Most likely, however, the term came from two Greek words *sun-* ("with") plus *kerannumi* ("mix") and its related noun, "krisis," "mixture. Syncretism is the fusion of differing systems of religious beliefs and practices. This is most evident in the areas of philosophy and religion, and usually results in a new teaching or belief system. Religious syncretism often takes place when foreign beliefs are introduced to an indigenous belief system and the teachings are blended. The new, heterogeneous religion then takes a shape of its own. The fusion of cultures that was effected by the conquest of Alexander the Great (4th century BCE), his successors, and the Roman Empire tended to

bring together a variety of religious and philosophical views that resulted in religious syncretism.

Historically, Gnosticism which was a religious dualistic system that incorporated elements from the Oriental mystery religions, Judaism, Christianity, and Greek religious philosophical concepts particularly prevalent during the Hellenistic period (c. 300 BCE–c. 300 CE) is a good example of syncretism. Another example of syncretic religion is Manichaeism, which was also a dualistic religion founded by the 3rd-century-CE Iranian prophet Mani, who combined elements of Christianity, Zoroastrianism, and Buddhism.

Religious syncretism is generally considered in Christian circles as an act apostasy (from Gk word *apostasia* – “standing away from”) which is tantamount to a renunciation or defection from one’s faith. Care must be taken to ensure that dialogue does not lead to any form of fusion of religious beliefs into any new sets of religious beliefs. Syncretism is different from religious inculturation or contextualization. Inculturation and contextualization do not lead to new religious beliefs but they enable religious prevailing beliefs find expression in human culture and language.

Lecture Week 8: Religious Identity and Dialogue

- ✓ Activity 1: Class Test/Mid-semester Exams
- ✓ Activity 2: Lectures cont.

Our discussion this week focuses on the place of one's religious identity in interreligious dialogue. Granted that interreligious dialogue is necessary and that the possible risks in its exercise can be avoided, there still remains the question of how much one's religious distinctiveness should show itself in interreligious contacts. Is care not needed to avoid provoking others? Is it not more prudent to dwell on what all share and to close our eyes on what distinguishes us?

Areas of Concern

- ⇒ Dialogue Presumes Differences
- ⇒ Religious Identity in a Statement of Belief
- ⇒ Religious Identity in Worship
- ⇒ Religious Identity in Comportment
- ⇒ Religious Identity in Celebration
- ⇒ Necessity of Religious Self-Image

■ DIALOGUE PRESUMES DIFFERENCES

If all humanity were members of only one religion, if all held the same beliefs, worshiped in the same way, and had the same code of conduct, there would be no need for interreligious dialogue. Dialogue presumes that there is diversity in religion. A dialogue partner becomes authentic when that person is a good representative of his or her religious tradition or community. This is important for any meaningful dialogue encounter. This makes the other believers clear about whom they are meeting. There can then be an exchange of gifts because none of the participants is a photocopy of the other. It is important to be who you are in any dialogue encounter. Your position must be clear. It is better to meet a genuine believer in dialogue encounter. It helps one to know the correct position of the dialogue partner. Believers who, while engaged in interreligious relations, would like to hide their religious identity, or at least to de-emphasize it, seem to be saying, without words, that their religion is an obstacle or an embarrassment to dialogue. This posture would be wrong. The purpose of dialoguing is to acknowledge and accept our differences. Believers must always realize and recognize who they are and to whom they bear witness. It is only then can they be good ambassadors of their religious traditions. We do not promote dialogue authentically by suppressing our religious identity.

If a religious dialogue partner loses his or her religious identity, then there is now no one left with whom to hold a dialogue. If a partner is hiding his or her identity, there can be several kinds of misgivings: suspicion, mistaken identity, belief that there is agreement where in fact there none etc. Likewise, if the partner is confused about his religious image, or is in search of a seemingly lost religious identity card, the consequence are not any less unpleasant. A clear picture to oneself of what one is with reference to religious affiliation, together with a quiet and sincere presentation of one's religious "visiting card" are among the fundamental requirements for fruitful interreligious dialogue. Such identity can refer to beliefs held, rites of prayer or worship, moral law or code of conduct, religious dress, or even religious terminology. "By their fruits, you shall know them" is a fundamental principle for a fruitful

dialogue. Dialogue partner must come to dialogue encounters with their real fruits so that all dialogue partners know the type of tree they belong.

▪ RELIGIOUS IDENTITY IN A STATEMENT OF BELIEF

Interreligious relations are not religious negotiation conferences where the representatives of each religion strive to see how many of their beliefs they can sell to others by expert bargaining. Interreligious dialogue is not even primarily or necessarily a statement and discussion of beliefs. A group of theologically well-prepared representatives of several religions can meet so often that mutual trust grows up between them to the level that they are well able to listen to one another's statements of beliefs, with all their convergences and divergences. Even at this level of mutual confidence, the participants should not be silent on points of belief where the group differs.

For example, a Christian in dialogue with a Muslim should not soft-pedal beliefs in the Most Blessed Trinity (three persons in only one God), in Jesus Christ as Son of God and God, in the Son of God becoming man and dying on the Cross for the salvation of all humanity, and in the Most Blessed Virgin Mary as the Mother of God. Muslims do not accept these doctrines. But a sincere friendly Muslim dialogue partner should not get angry that Catholic Christians hold all of them. On the other hand, a Muslim in dialogue should not hesitate to state that Muslims hold that the Qur'an is the last revelation from God and Muhammed the greatest and the last of the prophets. Buddhists do not speak about God or the soul, but Christians would be unauthentic if they did not. Sincerity about one's religious beliefs is part of dialogue.

The use of terms that have acquired definite meanings within religious communities needs particular attention when believers in different religions meet. Words like God, Divine Person, soul, heaven, salvation, redemption, perfection, grace, merit, charity, sin and hell do not necessarily mean the same things to Christians, Muslims, Buddhists, Hindus, and African Traditional Religionists. If such words are used in interreligious encounters, care should be taken to make their meaning clear. And a believer should not be too quick to copy a word loaded with meaning from another religion because of the dangers of misunderstanding and sometimes of unintended offense.

▪ RELIGIOUS IDENTITY IN WORSHIP

Most of the major religions of the world have a formally laid-out rite for public worship or prayer. They differ in the degree of detail or regulation. An authentic believer will worship according to the officially approved way of his or her religious family. In the Catholic Church, which I know best, there is, for example, a clear distinction between public prayer in the name of the Church (also called liturgical prayer), community prayer said by a group in their own name, and personal prayer particular to an individual. The Catholic Church is rather detailed in what she lays down for public prayer. Even the words and readings are fixed. There are some sections where the initiative of the chief celebrant or of the assembly is allowed in the introduction of their own words. It would therefore be a mistake for a Catholic priest to make changes that violate Church regulations and practice when he is celebrating the Holy Eucharist, just because some of the people present at that celebration come from other religions and will not agree with some of the formulas read out of Church books. Similarly, it would be wrong at a Catholic Eucharistic celebration to bring in readings from the sacred books of other religions, even if the ideas expressed in these are acceptable to Catholics. The reason is that authenticity, sincerity, and clear religious identity are expected of a dialogue partner, and sound Catholic practice does not allow such readings at Mass. Moreover, a reasonable Buddhist, Muslim, or Jew who attends a Eucharistic celebration in the Catholic Church is not expecting an interreligiously agreed rite, but should find it normal to see how his or her Catholic friends celebrate their public worship.

▪ RELIGIOUS IDENTITY IN COMPORTMENT

Most religions have prescriptions on how their follows are to behave in private or public life. The Catholic Church, for example, has a developed concept on how to live the faith as a follower of Christ. It has a branch of theology which deals specifically with right and wrong in matters of human conduct. She has even developed along the years a social doctrine on such matters as family, respect for life, rights and duties of citizens, the social obligations of the rich, relations between employees and employers, and so on. It has special legal code (Code of Canon Law) guiding and ensuring that the rights of its believers are upheld and protected within the church's life.

A religious believer who meets another believer is not expected to behave as if there were differences between what their religions demand in human conduct. That would be unrealistic. It would also be a refusal to share and to give witness. Some religions have instructions on when and where their followers should pray, or fast, or give alms, or make pilgrimages. Some religions prescribe what dress their followers or their ministers should wear during or outside worship. A Muslim should not be considered odd for praying at one corner a lorry station if his religion so prescribes at that time. The same thing applies to fasting during a month so indicated.

Religious dress needs special mention because it does attract considerable attention. Where there is no violation of the just laws of a country, a believer should not imagine that interreligious courtesy forbids him or her to put on the ordinary dress normal to that religion. If other believers resent this, they are being unreasonable. Interreligious courtesy does not require of a Catholic priest or a religious sister, a Muslim sheik, a Buddhist monk, a Shinto priest or a Sikh to hide one's religious identity in the way one dresses. To dress in the way that is normal in one's religion is not regarded as provocation. To try to hide one's identity in dress could cause suspicion.

▪ RELIGIOUS IDENTITY IN CELEBRATION

Every organized religion has some celebrations that are particular to it. These celebrations vary in their degree of importance and in the relative solemnity attached to them within that religion. The Jews, for example, celebrate Rosh Hashanah (first of the year) and Yom Kippur (the Day of Atonement), which comes ten days after, as well as other feasts. Christians celebrate the Incarnation of the Son of God, Jesus Nativity at Christmas, His suffering death, resurrection and ascension at Easter, the decent of the Holy Spirit on the early church on Pentecost Day and many others. Muslims celebrate Id al-Adha or Id al-Kabir (the feast of the Sacrifice of Abraham), Id al-Fitr or Id al-Saghir (feast of the Breaking of the Fast) and Mawlid al-Nabi (birthday of Muhammad). Traditional religionist, Buddhism, Shintoist, all have their own feast as well.

Interreligious dialogue does not ask a religious community to suppress its identity in its celebrations. It is not an offense to other religions to carry out a ritual that expresses the belief of one's religion. Indeed, a religion would endanger its permanence in its beliefs and practices, or at least weaken its coherence as a religious community if it did not have occasional celebrations of the major pillars of belief that give meaning to it and hold it together. The spirit of interreligious relations would suggest that some suitable form of invitation to other believers be considered at such celebrations. But no hard and fast rule should be entertained. There are religions that consider a celebration so particular to their "family" that the presence, let alone the active participation, of people who do not belong to that faith community cannot be considered. Every religion should strive to be true to itself. At occasions like marriages, funerals, anniversaries, local and national feast and whenever

neighborly and friendly relations so advise, invitations can be extended to people of other religions. Care must be taken, however, not confuse issues. Receiving communion in the Catholic Church on such occasions as non-Catholic believer is wrong thing to do. There is another way in which believers in one religion can show goodwill toward other believers who are celebrating a religious feast. They can send them a goodwill message. They can tell them to what extent the major belief or practice underlined in that celebration may be reflected in the other religion. The Pontifical Council for Interreligious Dialogue, for example, has since 1967 been sending a Message to the Muslims of the world during their month of fasting each year. The annual Message, now in its fiftieth edition, gathers a growing number of feedback messages and expressions of gratitude. From 1995 the Pontifical Council began to send a similar Message to Hindus during their celebration of *Diwali* and to Buddhists at the feast of *Vesak*. Some Muslims send messages to Christians at Christmas and New Year's Day. While every religious family has the right to retain its identity in its religious celebrations, it is also to be accepted that if one loves a person, one rejoices with that person when he or she celebrates a feast. The practical question is to agree on a mutually acceptable form that such a gesture of sharing the joy or sorrow of friends should take.

■ NECESSITY OF RELIGIOUS SELF-IMAGE

The above considerations help to see how necessary it is for a dialogue partner to have a clear religious self-image. Unless one knows clearly who one is and what one stands for, then the meeting with others is neither advisable nor safe. A country chooses as ambassador one of its citizens who is a credit to the country. It does not send as envoy to another country a citizen who does not know the name of the country's president, who cannot distinguish the country's flag from a lineup of four flags, who has no courage to identify what country he or she came from, and who does not like the national dress where such exists. A dialogue person is in a sense an ambassador.

Let it be repeated that quiet presentation of one's religious identity is not a form of provocation. It is not aggression. It is not intolerance. It is not fanaticism. It is simply being who and what one is, and meeting others in all honesty, sincerity, truth, and courage. If the dialogue partner wants one to hide or lose one's religious identity card as a condition for dialogue, then such a demand is unnecessary and unreasonable. It will also be found in practice that believers who make such demands are generally not open to dialogue. Religious believers therefore – Christians, Jews, Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists, Sikhs, Traditional Religionists, and others – should all in all sincerity meet one another as they are, present themselves without any masks, and strive to understand and accept one another, enrich one another, and work together without prejudice to build a better society within which they all life.

Week 9: Possibility of Doctrinal Dialogue

Is dialogue of theological exchange really possible? Is it not wiser to concentrate on other forms of dialogue?

Doctrinal dialogue or dialogue of discourse can provoke Heated Debates

Some believers are opposed to dialogue on items of belief because they consider that such will easily provoke heated debates. Each partner in the dialogue would like to defend his or her religious beliefs and prove that these are right. Some may even suggest the superiority of their beliefs over those of others and try to detect flaws or errors in these others. The expected reaction of the others need not be calm and sweet. The temperature of the debate is likely to rise. Agreement is not likely. A bitter taste could be left over from such an exercise. And no clear advantage can be detected. To some, therefore, it seems prudent to avoid doctrinal debates!

The answer is that this risk exists, but it can be avoided. To begin with, dialogue of theological exchange is not a debate on religious beliefs to see which side wins.

Week 7: Mid-semester Examinations

Week 8: Challenges of Interfaith & Interreligious Dialogue

Misunderstanding or misconception of Interreligious Dialogue

Using Dialogue for Apologetic Purposes

Respecting and accepting otherness of Partners of Dialogue

Week 9:

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